

Flavor fellow

Designing a platform that connects food lovers through challenges, mentorship, and cultural discovery

Original story

Food is more than flavor. It's connection, culture, creativity, and sometimes... **an identity.**

But in today's digital world, food experiences are mostly about scrolling and drooling, not **creating and sharing.**

I wanted to change that.

Flavor Fellow was born from the idea of turning passive food consumers into active culinary creators — through gamified recipe challenges, real chef mentorship, and an inclusive space where anyone could share their roots through what's on their plate.



The Problem I Wanted to Solve

Most food platforms focus on:

- Endless recipe libraries
- Restaurant discovery
- Aesthetic food videos with zero skill-building

But there's no digital space where:

- Young foodies can learn by doing
- Chefs can connect with passionate learners
- Cultural recipes can be explored and celebrated meaningfully

What Makes Flavor Fellow Different

- **Interactive Recipe Challenges:** Users recreate dishes with a twist and submit their version
- **Chef Mentorship:** Culinary professionals guide and judge community submissions
- **Culture-First:** Recipes come with backstories — from grandma's Diwali sweet to a rural Spanish stew
- **Fellowship System:** Top creators earn badges, level up, and even host future challenges

User Personas

Aarav (20) – College student, loves experimenting with cooking

“I don't want to just copy recipes. I want to create my own, and get feedback.”

Naila (29) – Home baker and self-taught chef

“I wish I had a way to connect with chefs or share my family recipes without needing a full blog.”

Core features I designed

Home Feed with Active Challenges

A dynamic scroll of open challenges — filterable by region, ingredient, or skill level.

Each card shows challenge title, chef host, deadline, and # of submissions.

Submission Flow

Simple 3-step interface:

- Upload your recipe photo
- Write your twist/story
- Optional: attach a 30-sec video
- Gamified with XP points and reaction badges (like "Bold Flavor" or "Culture Keeper").

Chef Profiles & Mentorship

Chefs have dedicated pages with their specialties, published challenges, and community Q&A boards.

Users can “Apply for 1:1 Mentorship” based on performance in challenges.

Cultural Recipe Archive

A curated section to explore food by region — e.g., Tamil Nadu Street Food, West African Staples, Ukrainian Festive Cuisine — with audio bites or stories from real locals.

Fellowships & Community Badging

Users earn badges like:

- Flavor Explorer (for global submissions)
- Fusion Master
- Tradition Teller
- These show up on their public profile and unlock secret chef Q&A rooms.

Unique Challenge System

Users participate in “Twisted Challenges” — recipe prompts with a creative constraint (e.g. “No Flame Cooking”, “Street Food x Home Kitchen”). Participants upload their own version with a story or cultural twist. Top entries earn points, recognition, and even real-world prizes.

Leaderboard & Gamification

A dynamic leaderboard tracks user performance across challenges. Badges like “Flavor Explorer” or “Fusion Master” reward creativity, consistency, and community engagement. This adds a sense of friendly competition and long-term motivation.

Chef Video Embeds

Professional chefs (and top community members) can embed short video clips — explaining techniques, sharing origin stories, or announcing new challenges. This makes content feel personal, educational, and mentorship-driven.

One-on-One Chef Booking

Users who consistently perform well can unlock private 1:1 mentorship slots with chefs. The booking system is integrated into the platform with time slots, short bios, and past ratings. It transforms passive content into real learning.

Real-Time Chat Interface

A built-in chat system allows participants to interact during or after challenges. Users can ask chefs questions, collaborate with others, or request feedback — fostering a vibrant, human-centered community.

What I learned

- People don't want perfect food — they want meaningful food
- Gamification needs to feel rewarding, not childish
- Chef-user connections must be guided, not just open-ended
- UX for a community platform must support energy + emotional safety

Flavor Fellow reminded me why I love designing for people — especially those who are passionate, talented, and just need the right space to grow. This project wasn't just about food. It was about giving people a reason to share it again.

